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BREAKING NEWS AT CHICAGOTRIBUNE.COM

Suburban Chicago man picked as Holy See ambassador

Trump's nominee for Vatican position has criticized pope

By Jonathan Bullington
Chicago Tribune

On March 7, 2016, the National Review published a letter signed by three dozen Catholic laypeople — some academics, some nonprofit leaders — that called Donald Trump “manifestly unfit to be president of the United States.”

Trump's campaign, they wrote, “has already driven our politics down to new levels of vulgarity. His appeals to racial and ethnic fears and prejudice are offensive to any genuinely Catholic sensibility.”

Among the signers was Brian Burch, a west suburban Chicago man who co-founded an advocacy group called Catholic-Vote about a decade earlier. Its self-described mission “is to inspire every Catholic in America to live out the truths of the Catholic faith in public life.”

Seven months later, Burch dramatically shifted his position on Trump; his organization went on to spend close to \$2 million trying to sway Catholic voters to support Trump's campaigns in 2020 and 2024.

Those efforts appear to have been rewarded. In December, Trump selected Burch to be the next U.S. ambassador to the Holy See; the nomination was formally sent to the U.S. Senate earlier this month for confirmation.

“He represented me well during the last Election, having garnered more Catholic votes than any Presidential Candidate in History!” Trump wrote on Truth Social. “Brian loves his Church and the United States — He will make us all proud.”

Burch's nomination comes amid simmering tensions between the Trump administration and the Vatican over immigration issues and cuts to aid programs. Some observers say his likely appointment could be a harbinger of continued turbulence given Burch's past criticism of Pope Francis, whose extended hospitalization has raised questions about how long the 88-year-old pontiff will remain the head of a Catholic Church that counts an estimated 53 million U.S. adults among its nearly 1.4 billion global flock. Francis returned to the Vatican on Sunday after nearly six weeks in Rome's Gemelli hospital battling a

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Pritzker ponders his options

Amid Donald Trump 2.0, the governor considers a potential third term and his national ambitions

By Rick Pearson | Chicago Tribune

The day after Donald Trump won the presidency last November, two-term Democratic Gov. JB Pritzker issued a statement that said as much about his plans for the state's future as his own political future.

“In 2017, I sought public office in large part because of the threat Donald Trump and his allies posed to Illinois,” he wrote, citing his successful first bid for governor in 2018. “I have helped enshrine into state law protections that uphold our common Illinois values. That work will continue, and it remains my North Star.”

With less than a year before the March 2026 primary and only four months before the period to gather candidacy petition signatures begins, Pritzker has yet to say

whether he will seek a rare but not unprecedented third term as governor.

But given his professed “North Star,” his sharp criticisms of the second Trump administration amid the listlessness of national Democratic Party leadership and a potential bid for the presidency in 2028, those who know and are close to the 60-year-old Pritzker say they expect him to seek reelection, with an announcement possibly coming after the legislature adjourns at the end of May.

Worth an estimated \$3.7 billion, according to Forbes, and having spent \$350 million to self-fund his two previous campaigns for governor, the heir to the Hyatt Hotels fortune finds himself with few political obstacles in the way of another run.

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Gov. JB Pritzker presides over a swearing-in ceremony in the state Senate chamber in January at the Illinois State Capitol in Springfield. **BRIAN CASSELLA/CHICAGO TRIBUNE**

CTA paid \$26K for vehicles used to commute

Documents show funds spent to get top officials to work

By Sarah Freishtat
Chicago Tribune

The CTA spent more than \$26,000 in 2023 and 2024 on three vehicles used by top officials at the public transit agency. In at least some instances, the vehicles were used more for commuting to and from work than for business purposes.

That was the case for an SUV used by former CTA President Dorval Carter, who reported about four times as many miles commuting as he did for business purposes during the months for which data was available, documents recently made public show.

From February to August 2023, Carter recorded driving 177.8 miles for business purposes and 774.4 miles commuting. Handwritten logs for subsequent months show a similar pattern.

The documents related to Carter were provided last week as part of a months-delayed response to a Tribune public records request for information about vehicle expenses for the CTA president, board members and 11 other top officials. The Tribune requested the records months before Carter announced his retirement in January, but did not receive a complete response until after his departure.

The latest CTA data comes after Carter and top CTA officials took heat for failing to regularly use the system they oversaw during the pandemic, as reported by Block Club Chicago and others. The car-use data sheds more light on the activities of CTA leaders and agency policies and spending.

“This dovetails, unfortunately, with concerns that the CTA president wasn't a regular transit user,” said Joseph Schwieterman, director of DePaul University's Chaddick Institute for Metropolitan Development.

The CTA took more than seven months to provide the complete set of information.

Public agencies in most cases legally have up to 10 days to respond to Freedom of Information Act requests. The CTA failed to provide any documents

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Shamrock Shuffle

A sea of runners make their way along State Street in the Loop during the 2025 Bank of America Shamrock Shuffle on Sunday. Nearly 27,000 runners joined the annual 8K race. In its 44th year, the run and 2-mile walk kicked off the Chicago outdoor running season. **BRIAN CASSELLA/CHICAGO TRIBUNE**

US talks terms with Ukraine and Russia

Opposing demands put mediators on steep path to truce

By Ivan Nechepurenko and Constant Méheut
The New York Times

The United States is holding separate talks with Russia and Ukraine in Saudi Arabia to iron out details of a possible limited ceasefire in what could be a crucial step toward a full cessation of hostilities in the war.

Russia and Ukraine agreed last week to pause strikes on energy infrastructure, but how and when to implement that partial truce are questions that have yet to be decided as attacks persist.

The talks — in Riyadh, the Saudi capital, with U.S. representatives mediating — are expected to focus on hammering out those details and on safety for shipping in the Black Sea.

“The agenda includes proposals to protect energy

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INSIDE

Death toll in Gaza war tops 50,000

The territory's Health Ministry announced the toll Sunday as new Israeli airstrikes killed at least 26 Palestinians overnight. **Nation & World**

TODAY'S WEATHER



High 49 Low 32

Complete Chicagoland forecast on Page 22

\$4.00 city and suburbs and elsewhere
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